

Разговор в WNBA больше не о баскетболе, и Софи Каннингем не понимает, почему



Защитница «Индиана Фивер» Софи Каннингем ведет мяч в матче против «Лас-Вегас Эйсес» в четверг вечером на стадионе «Гейнбридж Филдхаус» в Индианаполисе. «Эйсес» выиграли со счетом 86:84 в дополнительное время. Энди Лайонс / Getty Images



By **Candace Buckner**

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ИНДИАНАПОЛИС — это колонка о баскетболе. Именно такой ее хотела бы видеть Софи Каннингем.

другое.

В последнее время команда Каннингем оказалась в центре внимания из-за того, что она сказала [о трансгендерных женщинах в спорте](#). В интервью ESPN Каннингем заявила: «Я хочу защитить молодых девушек в раздевалке или молодых спортсменок, которым не нужно соревноваться с биологическими мужчинами». После этих комментариев ее товарищи по команде и главный тренер оказались втянуты в этот культурный скандал. Это означает, что, к большому огорчению Каннингема, баскетбол отошел на второй план.

«СМИ WNBA освещают все, кроме баскетбола, — заявила Каннингем в среду утром. — Как будто спрашиваешь себя: «Что мы делаем?»»

Каннингем никак не могла предвидеть, что ее резкие комментарии о чем-то, не связанном с баскетболом, вызовут настоящий медийный ажиотаж. Эта женщина полностью сосредоточена на баскетболе — за исключением, может быть, тех случаев, когда она ведет полурегулярный подкаст со звездой реалити-шоу. (В одном из недавних выпусков ведущий Уэст Уилсон нарушил молчание и рассказал, почему ушел из «Летнего дома». Это разительно отличается от [The Athletic подкаста No Offseason](#), в котором говорят только о баскетболе и прочем.)

Итак, позвольте этой истории сделать то, что редко кому удастся, — взять пример с «Индиана Фивер» из Женской национальной



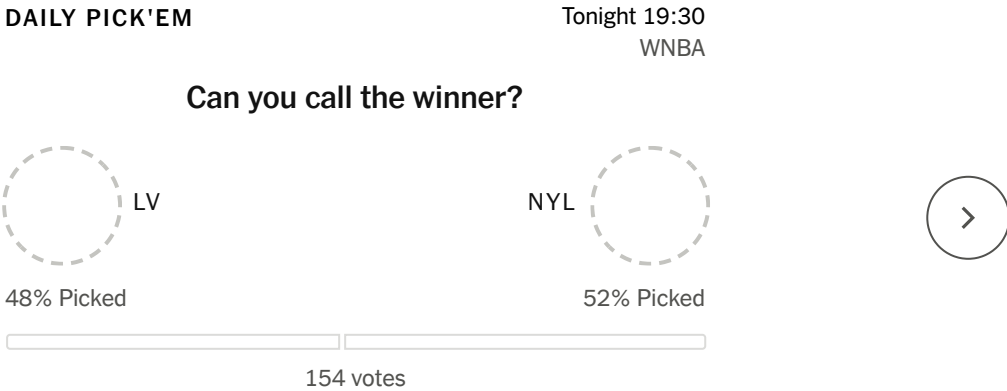
Как мы уже говорили: в четверг вечером «Фивер» и «Эйсес» провели очень зрелищный баскетбольный матч. Ну, до третьей четверти, когда игра была прервана на долгое время, пока звезда «Эйсес» Джеки Янг указывала на болельщика на трибуне, а охрана выводила двух мужчин. Они так и не вернулись на свои места. Команда заявила, что они не нарушали Кодекс поведения болельщиков, хотя Янг сказала, что один из мужчин «сделал (комментарий), который был немного чересчур».

Упс. Извините. Давайте переключимся на баскетбол, где защитница «Эйсес» Челси Грей стала первой в истории WNBA, кто в одной игре забил два редких решающих броска — трехочковый, который сравнял счет в конце основного времени, и еще один трехочковый, который принес победу в овертайме. Как вам такой баскетбольный анализ: у Грей было столько же решающих трехочковых, сколько очков набрала Каннингем.

Победа «Тузов» со счетом 86:84 в овертайме пришлась по душе всем, кто жаждет хаоса в концовке матча. А что касается того, что произошло ранее... с сожалением вынужден упомянуть, что один из демонстрантов провел около часа перед матчем у стадиона «Гейнбридж Филдхаус», рассказывая в мегафон о хромосомах.

Since Cunningham’s comments, there have been small groups of protestors demonstrating everywhere her team has resumed its basketball activities because of a topic that has little to do with basketball. In Seattle, in Portland and in Minneapolis, the groups have assembled in support of Cunningham. At times, they’ve met peaceful resistance. However, in downtown Indianapolis, one man paced alone with a sign that on one side read, in part: “No Child is Trans.”

A grandfather, holding a young girl’s hand, flipped the bird behind his back toward the demonstrator, and an Angel Reese fan from Dayton, Ohio, in town to celebrate her 70th birthday, stopped to talk with the man about his sign, she said she agreed but their conversation dovetailed into race. Mostly, the protest was ignored. Fans walked past him, delightfully unbothered so that they could take a photo beneath Caitlin Clark’s banner hanging outside the basketball arena.



Oh right, that reminds me again of basketball, and Clark, the Fever’s most popular basketball player.

eventually score, however, and on her first bucket she moved around her former teammate, Aces center Brianna Turner. This is the same player who recently had made ripples for non-basketball reasons when she accused the Fever of allegedly silencing players after the team had fired a male staffer over sexual harassment claims. The Fever [denied Turner's allegations](#) two weeks later.

But back to basketball, where on Thursday, Clark and teammate Aliyah Boston were named to the USA Basketball roster for September's FIBA Women's Basketball World Cup in Berlin. Also this week, Clark's other All-Star teammate, Kelsey Mitchell, earned Eastern Conference Player of the Month honors for July. Fever fans can't get enough of their basketball stars, and during the game against the Aces, one woman held up a small sign: "CC + Kelsey MVP." In Indiana, Clark is viewed as a Most Valuable Player.

However, in MAGA spaces, she's called a ["coward."](#)

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It feels non-basketbally to bring up that Clark has refused to wade into the conversation that Cunningham sparked about trans women in sports. Initially, after the controversy began, Clark did not speak with reporters. When her absence from the frontlines of this cultural war was noted, and when pro-Cunningham demonstrations continued to overshadow the basketball, Clark finally said: "It's for leagues and the governing bodies to work with their athletes to find solutions, but our focus is on basketball."



Clark has since been torn down by members of the very community that had held her up as its representative. Cunningham, meanwhile, got a shout-out from [Indiana's Lt. Gov. Micah Beckwith](#), who once defended the purpose behind the Three-Fifths Compromise of 1787, which counted enslaved people as three-fifths of a human.

Beckwith said he was “proud” that Cunningham was a Hoosier, and his praise had little to do with her basketball skill set. People like him are not actually listening to Cunningham when she says let’s focus on sports, they’re using her. And they don’t actually care about basketball. Just listen to them.

basketball. My girls play basketball, but I don't want to cover women's basketball. I don't want to be a WNBA analyst. We get paid to have an opinion about everything. And this is something I don't care about."

In other news of conservative men supporting women, Outkick founder Clay Travis, who has called Cunningham "a rock star," spent the week baiting the Aces, the defending WNBA champs, to a \$10 million payday if they defeated a boys' state championship team. Cunningham, for some reason, reserved her criticism for the WNBA media.

This is the problem that hounds the Fever. No matter how much the media, the fans and especially the players want to focus on basketball, the sideshow overshadows everything on the court. The protestors and politicians keep showing up. The blue check marks in Elon's rage arena keep posting about this sport with impure intentions. It's so exhausting.

For her part, Cunningham is trying to have it both ways. She throws gasoline on the complex discussion of trans women in sport, and fans those flames by spending time before the Aug. 2 game in Minneapolis, [smiling and posing for photos with women wearing XX XY T-shirts](#). Then she complains when WNBA media notice what she stands for.

Cunningham wants all the good that comes with her proximity to a superstar like Clark, and the newfound fame she has built with her own outspokenness, but she wants none of the consequences. It would be nice for her if the world worked like that, just like it would be nice if the rest of us could stick to basketball.

Candace Buckner is a national columnist at The Athletic. She began writing sports commentary and criticism for The Washington Post in 2021. Overall, her career spans nearly 25 years, stretching from Columbus (Ga.), Macon (Ga.), Kansas City (Mo.), Gary (Ind.), Vancouver (Wash.) and Indianapolis. For the past four years, she has earned Top 10 honors in the Division A column writing category from the Associated Press Sports Editors, including first place in the 2024 APSE contest. Buckner's work has also been included in The Best American Sports Writing.

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